



HEALER EXTRAORDINAIRE

Prathap C. Reddy, Founder Chairman of Apollo Hospitals, pioneered the private healthcare industry in India, and changed forever the country's health ecosystem. Reddy reminisces about his life and times

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THE PLAYBOOK IS well worn: (i) Move abroad for higher studies; (ii) work overseas; (iii) identify a problem statement in India and devise a solution; (iv) move back; (v) build a successful company. These are the five steps to success for many recent Indian entrepreneurs. Dr Prathap C. Reddy, 91, winner of this year's BT-PwC India's Best CEOs award

for Lifetime Achievement, did something similar, but 50 years ago!

Reddy completed his MBBS from Chennai's Stanley Medical College and then trained in the US. He then had a flourishing practice as a cardiologist. One day, a letter arrived from his father, which had a profound impact. Reddy and his family decided to return to India in the early

1970s. Back in Chennai, his practice flourished, but he also faced a stark reality: a lack of medical infrastructure. He was forced to refer most of his patients who needed complex surgeries to friends in the US. Many were referred to pioneering heart surgeon, Dr Denton Cooley.

Around 1979, Reddy referred a patient to the US. But the man's family

could not raise the money required. And despite Reddy's best efforts, he did not survive. Reddy then decided to set up a cardiac care hospital in India.

But nobody had set up a corporate hospital in India before. Undeterred, he sought the government's support, making several trips to Delhi to meet ministers and bureaucrats. On one such trip, he

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➤ The Medicine Man

❶ Prathap C. Reddy's vision was to create an integrated healthcare ecosystem. Under him, Apollo Hospitals has become the world's largest integrated healthcare provider, with 71+ hospitals, 10,000+ beds, nearly 6,000 pharmacies, 200+ clinics and diagnostic centres, and 150 telemedicine centres

❷ He advocated for mandatory health insurance, initiating a ₹1-a-day insurance project, laying the groundwork for India's universal health insurance programme